Shiva must have appeared when first shown to the public in procession, as a golden dancer with one foot raised and hair streaming across the firmament – an image so radical and so revolutionary that it could only have been made with powerful royal backing.

This was part of the repositioning of Lord Shiva by his royal devotees as supreme among the gods: Shiva reinterpreted as cosmic mover and shaker, in which role he performs the *tandavam* or *tandava ananda*, the divine dance, in order to create, maintain and destroy the universe in one cosmic cycle after another. Ringed by a circle of fire, the lord of yogis treads on the recumbent figure of Muyalakan (known outside Tamil Nadu as Apasmara), the dwarf demon of arrogance and ignorance. In his right upper hand he shakes his double-sided yogic drum, the *damaru*, to mark the passing of time, in his left he holds fire, symbolising the dissolving of the world. With one open hand on his left he protects humanity while the other lower hand outstretched offers solace. In his headdress is a skull, representing both death and time. Entangled in his hair is the goddess Ganga, caught in Shiva's locks in her descent from heaven to water the earth.

The devotee who worshipped Shiva as Nataraja would not have missed the link between the cosmic-encompassing god and his royal representative on earth. Here was a manifestation fit for a dynasty of empire-makers and wheel-turning *chakravartin*.

This brazen manifestation of Lord Shiva as cosmic dancer took off in Tamil country in the ninth century and very quickly spread throughout the South. But it was not entirely original, being more in the nature of the apotheosis of a new way of representing Lord Shiva that had first appeared in stone under the aegis of the kings of two quite distinct Kannada-speaking dynasties of the western Deccan: the Early Chalukyas and the Rashtrakutas.